Still, you cannot discount Akbar's joy at Hayran's return. Akbar loved animals, and animals can love back in a way that no human can; the wildness of the horse and the fury of the boy may have been like balm to one another. Akbar got back in his saddle and returned to camp, his temper restored. His relationship with Bairam, however, had only suffered the first of many bumps in a long and rocky decline.

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Five days after Sikandar Suri surrendered, the victorious Mughal army packed up and went to Lahore. Akbar raced ahead, hunting all the way. Bairam brooded. In Lahore, says Nizamuddin, the regent 'still harped upon' the elephant fight – but his suspicions had shifted from Akbar to his ataka, Shamsuddin Muhammad Khan.

Like Bairam, Shamsuddin began his career as a soldier. Unlike Bairam, he had no claim to any kind of name. Bairam descended from a well-known clan of Baharlu Turks; his father was governor of Ghazni under Babur, the very province in which Shamsuddin's father was a farmer. The class difference is clear in the fact that Abul Fazl doesn't include Shamsuddin in his list of commanders who came to Hindustan with Humayun; Shamsuddin was part of the retinue, yes, but he came as an attendant, not a warrior.[57] The two men did have one thing in common, however: they were both hugely ambitious.

Back on his farm in Ghazni, a twenty-two-year-old Shamsuddin had dreamt of holding the moon in his arms. Following the lucky accident by which he rescued Humayun in Kannauj, the young soldier had gained a place of intimate trust in Humayun's life. His wife, Jiji, was one of Akbar's many affectionate anakas – in fact, she had been the first foster mama to hold the newborn. Their son, Aziz, was Akbar's *koka*, milk brother, and would remain his friend until the end of Akbar's life. The padishah was the moon of Shamsuddin's dreams – and a man who had held Akbar in his arms from infancy would have a far greater hold on his love, and trust, than Bairam could hope for. Might the ataka, then, usurp the regent's role?

Bairam turned on him. Akbar's seeming 'disfavour' Bairam could only blame on Shamsuddin's 'calumnies'. Why, asked Bairam, was Shamsuddin 'thirsting for my blood', and turning Akbar against him such that the young